

16, The Exceedingly Sluggish Formation of the Genuine Classical Iran

Next, let us shift our gaze to Iran. Previously, when discussing the history of the Islamic world, the most recent fourteen centuries of Iranian history have already been incorporated into our framework. What we must consider now is that protracted epoch—spanning over ten centuries, yet lacking in conspicuous mutations—of **classical Iran**.

Regarding the political organization of the Achaemenid Empire (阿契美尼德帝国), the military superiority upon which the empire's foundation relied was bound to vanish sooner or later, because potential adversaries would inevitably learn and adapt. The financial advantage the empire established through coinage and commercial circulation would equally be crippled by the natural bloating of the bureaucratic system. The myriad autonomous entities that initially submitted—temporarily awed by the conquerors' might—would inevitably question the necessity of continuing their subjugation to a "King of Kings." In reality, it is profoundly difficult to categorize this system itself as stable. That it managed to exist for over two centuries forces one to admit that the martial prowess of the Perso-Median coalition (*undoubtedly including some Aryan tribes further east*) was genuinely astonishing!

Although the empire's demise was entirely unsurprising, the individual who annihilated the empire became a transcendent legend. However, contrary to the colossal sensory shock Alexander the Great's (亚历山大大帝) conquests inflicted upon observers, this conquest brought exceptionally minor changes to the actual essence of Persian society—and arguably, to the essence of the entire Middle Eastern society!

From the Macedonian conquest to the Seleucid Empire (塞琉古帝国), the Greeks in Persia differed drastically from the Greeks in Egypt. They essentially did not intermarry with the local populace and confined themselves to living within cities. This was highly likely because the local **communities** (社群) in the Persian region remained formidably robust. While the upper-class culture of the Persian region undeniably absorbed Greek influences, the fundamental historical trajectory of Persia itself continued to operate strictly according to its own organic rhythm.

The Arsacid Empire (安息帝国 / Parthian Empire) that supplanted the Seleucids originated in what is now northeastern Iran. The local autonomy of various regions within the Arsacid Empire was far stronger than under the Achaemenid Dynasty; this state's aristocratic assembly even possessed the authority to depose the king! Judging from the geographical distribution of the state's seven most formidable noble houses, the entire Iranian plateau at that time was essentially controlled by several massive tribal confederacies. Although documentary records regarding this regime are exceedingly scarce, we can deduce that the rise of the Arsacid Empire was the consequence of further regional development in Iran; the diffusion of technology—particularly military technology—spawned a new cohort of formidable tribes across the Iranian plateau. While the Arsacid family was the most powerful, their strength fundamentally did not reach an overwhelming imbalance compared to other aristocrats, ultimately resulting in a loosely bound organizational morphology.

Considering that the so-called "Seven Great Noble Houses" of the Arsacid Empire (安息帝国七大贵族) maintained colossal influence straight through the subsequent rule of the Sasanian Empire (萨珊帝国), it is glaringly obvious that during the Arsacid epoch, Iran was still a monumental distance away from genuinely entering a **classical society**!

Contemporary with the Arsacid Empire, Rome had already surged into the zenith of its **classical era**. Coupled with the fact that Rome inherently held an overwhelming advantage in territory and population, the balance of power between Rome and Parthia tilted increasingly toward the former. However, after the establishment of the Sasanian Empire, the situation began to drastically reverse! **Just as Rome plunged into decline due to its feudalization process, the Sasanian Empire was marching aggressively toward the absolute zenith of its classical era!**

After enduring nine centuries as an "**early classical society**", Iran finally crossed the threshold into a highly typical **classical society** during the reigns of the King of Kings Kavād I (卡瓦德一世) and his son Khosrau I (库斯劳一世 / Khosrow I).

During their combined 80-year rule, these two generations of monarchs executed virtually every crucial imperative required of a **classical monarch**! They actively weaponized the socio-religious demands and movements of the Mazdakites (马兹达克派) as political instruments to suppress the high aristocracy and cripple the clergy. They radically reformed the taxation system, abolished the tax-exemption privileges historically monopolized by the grand aristocrats (*headed by the Seven Great Houses of Parthia*), rigorously surveyed land across the empire, and implemented a capitation tax (人头税).

Crucially, the King of Kings vigorously patronized and cultivated a class of minor landlords known as the **Dehqan** (德赫坎 / Dehgan). The monarchs deliberately orchestrated their increasingly dominant representation within the political bureaucracy, enabling the **landlord class** to gradually secure paramountcy within the empire, thereby solidifying the **feudal mode of production** as the mainstream. The meteoric rise of the *Dehqan* also triggered profound mutations in the Sasanian military apparatus, transforming them into the absolute backbone of the army! **This specific dynamic bears a striking resemblance to the Western Han Dynasty in our nation.**

Khosrau I also constructed massive military and public engineering projects, such as the Great Wall of Gorgan (戈尔甘长城) in the northeast, the Nahrawan Canal (纳赫拉万运河) near Baghdad, and the Taq Kasra (塔克基斯拉宫) frequently featured in documentaries, renowned today for the Arch of Ctesiphon (泰西封拱门).

Khosrau I was equally a ravenous patron of philosophy and knowledge, exhibiting the intense curiosity and desire to assimilate the external world characteristic of a zenith **classical monarch**. The King of Kings granted asylum to philosophers fleeing the Byzantine Empire, displayed monumental interest in the philosophical, mathematical, and academic achievements of India, and repeatedly commissioned the translation of Greek, Sanskrit, and Syriac texts into Pahlavi (Middle Persian / 巴列维语). During Khosrau I's reign, the Academy of Gondishapur (贡迪沙普尔学院) was massively expanded to support these translation endeavors. One can also unearth glorious civilizational achievements of a **classical empire** here, such as the advanced hospitals known as *Bimaristan* (Bimaristan 医院).

Undeniably, the reign of Khosrau I marked the absolute golden age of Sasanian Persia. This was forged both by his formidable personal capabilities and, more crucially, by the geopolitical timing! Not only did he capitalize on the phenomenally brief window of a **classical society** characterized by explicit class transition within Iran's 4,000-year social evolution, but simultaneously, Iran's greatest rival—the Byzantine Empire—was actively being hollowed out by the rampant proliferation of domestic **feudal manors** (封建庄园).

Dramatically, under normal circumstances, Iran's population and economy were vastly inferior—not merely compared to the Roman Empire at its zenith encompassing the Mediterranean, but even compared to the fragmented Eastern Empire alone! **However, this exact "historical time-lag" in societal stage development dictated that throughout the entire 6th century AD, Iran found itself in an increasingly advantageous position in its military confrontations against Byzantium!**

The Kings of Kings fundamentally possessed zero scientific understanding of macroscopic social development. They likely genuinely believed that Iran's surging power was a direct manifestation of their own omnipotence! Consequently, they increasingly underestimated the Byzantine Empire, initiated megalomaniacal plans with unachievable objectives, and remained utterly oblivious as to where the *true*, apocalyptic existential threat would soon emerge from.

16, 真正的古典伊朗形成十分缓慢

接下来把目光放到伊朗，之前在讨论伊斯兰世界历史的时候已经把伊朗历史的最近将近 14 个世纪给纳入进来了，现在要考虑的就是那个漫长的超过十个世纪的，但是变化并非显著的古典伊朗。就阿契美尼德帝国的政治组织而言，帝国建立仰仗的军事优势早晚会消失，因为潜在的敌人一样会学习；帝国依赖货币和流通建立的财政优势，也会随着官僚系统自然的臃肿化而被削弱；最初慑于征服者威势暂时臣服的各个自治实体，早晚会怀疑自己有没有必要再向一个万王之王臣服。实际上这种体制本身就很难说稳定，它能够存在两个多世纪人们都不得不说波斯-米底联合的武力优势确实惊人（当然也包括更东方的一些雅利安部落）。尽管帝国灭亡并不奇怪，但是灭亡帝国的人却成为一个传奇。然而与亚历山大大帝的征服在感官上带给人们的巨大冲击不同，这场征服对于波斯帝国社会的本质，甚至可以说整个中东社会的本质带来的变化很小。从马其顿征服到塞琉古帝国（Seleucid），在波斯的希腊人甚至不同于在埃及的希腊人，他们基本不和当地人通婚，并且居住在城市中，这有可能是波斯地区本地社群比较强势的原因。就波斯地区上层阶级的文化上看，肯定会受到希腊的影响，但是波斯本身的历史进程仍然依照自己的节奏运行。

取代塞琉古的安息帝国（Arsacid）发迹于现在伊朗的东北部，比阿契美尼德王朝安息帝国各地方的自治性更强，这个国家的贵族议会甚至可以废黜国王。就该国七个最为强力的贵族的分布来看，当时的整个伊朗高原被几个大部族所控制。虽然有关这个政权的文献资料很少，不过我们可以推测安息帝国的崛起是伊朗地区进一步得到开拓的结果，技术特别是军事技术的扩散使得伊朗高原出现了一批新的强大部族。虽然安息家族最为强大，只不过与其他贵族之间的力量并没有失衡，因此最终形成了一种松散的组织形式。考虑到所谓的安息帝国七大贵族一直在萨珊帝国统治期间都有巨大影响力，安息帝国存在时期伊朗显然离古典社会还有很大差距。与安息帝国同期的罗马已经进入古典时代盛期，再加上罗马的领土和人口原本就占尽优势，罗马和帕提亚之间的天平越来越倾向于前者。等到萨珊帝国建立之后情况开始发生逆转，在罗马因为封建化进程陷入衰落的同时，萨珊帝国正在向古典时代的鼎盛期迈进。

在经历了九个世纪的“早期古典社会”之后，在万王之王卡瓦德一世（Kavad）和他的儿子库斯劳一世（Khosrau，也翻译成霍斯劳\霍斯罗）在位时期伊朗终于进入了典型的古典社会。这两代统治者在他们统治的 80 年间几乎做了古典君主需要做的一切重要事项。他们利用马兹达克派的诉求和运动作为遏制贵族，削弱神职人员的政治工具。他们改革税收制度，取消了安息七大家族为首大贵族的免税特权，丈量帝国内的土地并且开始收取人头税。万王之王大力扶植一种被称为德赫坎（Dehgan）的小地主，有意识地让他们在政治官僚体制中占比越来越大，使得地主阶级在帝国内逐渐取得优势，封建生产方式成为主流。德赫坎的崛起也让萨珊帝国的军事体制出现了变化，现在他们成为军队的中流砥柱，这一点跟我国西汉时期颇为相似。库斯劳一世修建了众多军事工程和大型公共工程，例如东北方向的戈尔甘长城，巴格达附近的纳赫拉万运河（Nahrawan Canal），以及纪录片中经常出现的塔克基斯拉宫，现在以泰西封拱门而著称。

库斯劳一世还是一位哲学和知识的赞助者，表现出了古典君主特有的对于外部世界的强烈好奇心和接纳的欲望。万王之王接受从拜占庭逃难的哲学家，对于印度的哲学，数学等学术成果表现出了极大的

兴趣，他数次将希腊语，梵语和叙利亚语的文本翻译为巴列维语（中古波斯语）。在库斯劳一世执政时期，贡迪沙普尔学院（Gondishapur）被极大扩展并支持翻译工作。人们也能够找到古典帝国的辉煌文明成果，例如被称为 Bimaristan 的医院。毫无疑问，库斯劳一世的统治标志着萨珊波斯的鼎盛年代，这既是他个人能力所造就的，更是时运所致。他不仅赶上了伊朗 4000 年社会发展历史上很短一段阶级交替明显出现的古典社会，而且伊朗最大的竞争对手拜占庭正在被国内林立的封建庄园削弱。戏剧性的是，虽然在一般情况下不要说与鼎盛期包含地中海的罗马帝国相比，即便和分裂之后的东帝国相较，伊朗帝国的人口和经济上也处于劣势。然而伊朗和拜占庭社会阶段发展的时差使得在整个公元六世纪伊朗在与拜占庭的军事对抗中处于越来越有利的形势。万王之王对于社会发展完全没有什么科学理解，他们大概真的以为伊朗变得强大是自己无所不能的体现，因而愈发轻视拜占庭帝国，不但开始计划难以达成的目标，而且完全不知道真正可能的危险出现在何处。